

FREE RESOURCE · PROJECT MANAGEMENT

Project Closure Checklist

20 actions covering deliverable sign-off, financial closure, documentation handover, and team release — with a lessons learned guide and formal sign-off section.

20 Closure Actions

4 Phases

Sign-off Section

Lessons Learned

20 actions

4 phases

Sign-off section

Lessons prompts

HOW TO USE

Complete each item before submitting for sign-off. Items with notes (in grey italic) explain why the action matters and what good looks like. Do not skip items — partial closure creates risk for the organisation and the project manager.

Phase 1 — Deliverables & Acceptance

- ☐ **01. Confirm all project deliverables have been completed and accepted**
Each deliverable should have a formal sign-off from the agreed acceptance authority. Do not proceed to closure until all deliverables are either accepted or formally descoped.
- ☐ **02. Obtain written acceptance sign-off from the project sponsor or client**
A verbal sign-off is not sufficient for formal project closure. The sign-off should reference the project charter or contract scope.
- ☐ **03. Confirm all outstanding change requests have been resolved or formally deferred**
Unresolved change requests must be either implemented, rejected, or formally transferred to a BAU backlog before the project can close.
- ☐ **04. Confirm that all contractual obligations to third parties have been met**
Review all vendor contracts, SOWs, and licence agreements. Confirm delivery against each obligation and obtain vendor confirmation where required.
- ☐ **05. Verify that all system integrations and data migrations are complete and validated**
Where applicable, confirm that integration testing has been completed and signed off. Data migration should be validated by the data owner, not just the technical team.

Phase 2 — Knowledge & Documentation

- ☐ **06. Archive all project documentation in the agreed project repository**
Documents should be organised by category (charter, plans, reports, decisions, contracts) and access permissions set for the transition period.

☐ **07. Complete and archive all meeting minutes, decision logs, and action logs**

Decision logs are particularly important — they provide the rationale for key choices made during the project and are frequently needed in post-project reviews.

☐ **08. Ensure all technical documentation is complete and handed to the operational team**

Technical documentation includes architecture diagrams, configuration records, runbooks, and user guides. Confirm receipt in writing from the operational team.

☐ **09. Complete the project closure report**

The closure report summarises what was delivered, what was not delivered, final budget position, key lessons, and recommendations for future projects.

☐ **10. Confirm that all outstanding risks and issues have been resolved or transferred**

Risks and issues that cannot be resolved before closure must be formally transferred to the operational risk register or BAU owner, not simply closed.

Phase 3 — Financial Closure

☐ **11. Confirm final project costs and reconcile against the approved budget**

The final cost reconciliation should cover all cost categories: internal resource, third-party spend, licences, and any capitalised costs.

☐ **12. Ensure all invoices have been received, approved, and processed**

Outstanding invoices should be accrued in the final accounting period. Do not close the project cost code until all expected invoices have been received.

☐ **13. Obtain formal approval to close the project cost code**

Budget owners and Finance should both confirm in writing that the cost code can be closed. Premature closure creates reconciliation problems.

☐ **14. Confirm that any unused budget has been formally released or reallocated**

Unused project budget should be formally returned to the sponsoring business unit or programme fund. This requires explicit approval, not automatic release.

☐ **15. Complete the final financial report and obtain Finance sign-off**

The final financial report should show total spend vs budget, a brief explanation of any variance, and the final cost-per-deliverable where applicable.

Phase 4 — Team Release & Recognition

☐ **16. Formally release all project team members back to their line managers**

Send formal written confirmation to each line manager. Include the release date and a summary of the team member's contribution to the project.

☐ **17. Ensure all project-related access rights and system permissions have been revoked**

Work with IT or the system administrator to remove temporary project access. This is a security control, not just a housekeeping step.

☐ **18. Conduct team debrief and lessons learned session**

The lessons learned session should be a structured conversation, not an email survey. Allow at least 60 minutes. Use the Lessons Learned Prompts on page 2 to guide the discussion.

☐ **19. Recognise team contributions formally — send thank-you communications**

Acknowledge individual contributions in writing. Copy line managers where appropriate. Recognition at project close significantly affects team willingness to work on future projects.

☐ **20. Confirm that all team members have updated their CVs or project records**

Project experience is valuable for professional development. Encourage team members to document their role and key achievements before the project details fade.

Lessons Learned — Discussion Prompts

Conduct the lessons learned session as a structured conversation with the full project team before project closure. Allow a minimum of 60 minutes. Record the key points below and include a summary in the project closure report.

1. What went well on this project that we should repeat on future projects?

Consider: delivery approach, team collaboration, stakeholder management, tools used, decisions made.

2. What did not go well and should be done differently next time?

Be specific — 'communication was poor' is not actionable. Name the specific breakdown and what would have prevented it.

3. What did we underestimate at the start of the project?

Common answers: complexity, stakeholder resistance, data quality issues, third-party dependencies, scope creep.

4. What would we do differently if we were starting this project today?

This is often the most valuable question — it surfaces the implicit knowledge the team has built up during delivery.

5. What should the organisation learn from this project?

Think beyond the project team — what process, governance, or capability gaps does this project reveal at an organisational level?

6. What risks materialised that we should have identified earlier?

Review the risk log. For each risk that became an issue, identify whether it could have been detected and mitigated earlier.

Formal Project Sign-Off

By signing below, the named individuals confirm that the project has been formally closed, all deliverables accepted, financial closure completed, and documentation archived.

BEFORE SIGNING

All 20 checklist items must be completed. The project manager should retain a copy of the signed closure checklist in the project archive.

PROJECT MANAGER

Name	Signature	Date

PROJECT SPONSOR

Name	Signature	Date

FINANCE SIGN-OFF

Name	Signature	Date

IT / OPERATIONS SIGN-OFF

Name	Signature	Date